

Spotting & Supporting a Struggling Student

A flowchart of the process I want to follow in my classroom — from first noticing a struggle, to telling a language need apart from a learning disability, to the special education referral process. (Based on research — see references, p. 2.)

How to read this

-  a step I take
-  a decision point
-  keep-monitoring loop

1. Notice the signs

Look for a **cluster of signs over time**, not one bad day: trouble following multi-step directions, word-finding ("the thing..."), letter/sound or counting & pattern struggles, avoiding reading, frustration or acting out.

(Morin, 2021; NCLD, n.d.)

2. Document it & build a learning profile

Keep an observation tracker, work samples, and screening data. Profile the **whole learner** — strengths, interests, how they learn best — not just scores. Try quick supports: visual directions, think-alouds, immediate feedback.

(TeachThought Staff, 2023; Morin, 2021)

3. Partner with the family early

Share specific, judgment-free examples and **listen**: health & developmental history, language(s) at home, past schooling. Respond quickly and follow through — trust matters later in this process.

(American Federation of Teachers, n.d.)

Does the student speak a language other than English at home (English learner)?

yes!

no

Language difference ... or disability?

Before any referral, team up with the ESL specialist / bilingual SLP and ask:

- Do difficulties show up in **both languages** and **across settings** (home and school)?
- How does the student compare to "**true peers**" with a similar language background & schooling?
- Has the student had enough **high-quality, EL-appropriate instruction**? Rule out limited English exposure & interrupted schooling first.

(The IRIS Center, n.d.; Medina, 2018; Colorín Colorado, n.d.)

4. Tiered interventions (MTSS / RTI)

Tier 1: strong, differentiated core instruction for everyone

Tier 2: targeted small-group help + progress monitoring (≈6–8 wks)

Tier 3: intensive, individualized intervention with the support team

Interventions must be research-based — and appropriate for ELs when it applies.

(Medina, 2018; LDA of America, n.d.)

no — it shows in both languages

Do the struggles appear only in English, and look like typical second-language acquisition?

yes

Is the student making adequate progress — and do I have the data to show it?

support + keep monitoring

no — not enough progress

It's a language need — not special ed!

Do **not** refer. Provide EL supports: sheltered instruction, visuals & realia, vocabulary support, extra processing time. Keep monitoring growth and stay in touch with the family.

(Medina, 2018; The IRIS Center, n.d.)

5. Refer for a special education evaluation

With the support team & family: written referral + **parent consent** → full, unbiased evaluation in the child's home language, within 60 days.

(Project IDEAL, n.d.)

Yes → keep it up!

Continue what's working, celebrate growth with the student & family, and stay watchful with ongoing data.

(American Federation of Teachers, n.d.)

6. Eligibility meeting

Parents + team decide two things: does the child have a **disability under IDEA** (e.g., specific learning disability, speech/language impairment, intellectual disability) **and** does it require special education?

(LDA of America, n.d.; American Psychiatric Association, n.d.)

Eligible → IEP written & implemented: goals, services, least restrictive environment; reviewed yearly, re-evaluated every 3 yrs. (NCLD, n.d.-b)

Not eligible → back to classroom supports & monitoring; consider a 504 plan; the door stays open if concerns continue. (LDA of America, n.d.)

References

The short tags in parentheses on the flowchart match the sources below.

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